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FEATURED

San Mateo Police Department restricts data sharing

Officials limit sharing permissions and implement strict database audits to identify potential misuse

By Cecilia Schutz Daily Journal staff
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Ez a webhely olyan technológiákat használ, mint a cookie-k a webhely alapvető funkcióinak, valamint a elemzések, személyre szabás és célzott reklámozás számára.
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The San Mateo Police Department has tightened the reins on its real time information center technology, which includes the use and control of automated license plate readers, body cameras and drones, by limiting sharing permissions to select jurisdictions and implementing strict database audits to identify potential data misuse.

These changes, presented at the City Council special meeting Monday, mirror the recommendations issued by the San Mateo County Civil Grand Jury report, released Aug. 3, that reviewed San Mateo County's police agencies' use of ALPRs. The report didn't find any illegal, out-of-state data-sharing as of December 2025, but did see sharing with private universities and noted that unauthorized data access and insufficient oversight mechanisms for the cameras remains a concern.

To bolster their data protections, the police significantly reduced the number of agencies it was sharing data with, from over 280 at its height, to now just eight. It has removed sharing with all university police departments, and is now requiring every agency to sign a sharing agreement. San Mateo police can deny a sharing request or terminate an agreement if an agency was involved in a data breach. Requests for sharing are handled by police Lt. Steve Casazza.

"We've really limited our sharing just to have more control over the data and who it gets to," Casazza said.

Flock Safety, a technology used within RTIC to respond to emergencies, apprehend people suspected of crimes and identify stolen vehicles and missing people, offers permanent audit trails and automatic data deletion — a tool San Mateo police have continued to use, with some modifications.

The agency started requiring case numbers, along with a computer-aided dispatch number for emergency calls, and a search reason to supervise how the database is being used, so San Mateo police can have more oversight and ensure searches are for legitimate and justifiable purposes, said Casazza. Every search is tied to an authorized user, and while users document the offense type, search details are recorded into the database and audited monthly.

RTIC integrates real-time information from law enforcement technology, such as live camera feeds, drones, license plate reading and mapping, to assist San Mateo police officers with quick responses to emergencies and crimes.

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Between 2024, the year RTIC was first established, and 2025, San Mateo police observed a 25% drop in property crime and a 20% decrease in violent crime, which it partially attributes to the application of RTIC. Councilmember Lisa Diaz

Nash said she felt “very impressed” with the department’s work on RTIC, and wants to “support its continuance” through consistent data auditing.

“I have seen the incredible benefit that the community has received from this technology, and I would be very interested in keeping a close eye on what is going forward, and having periodic reporting to the council,” she said.

Echoing Diaz Nash, Councilmember Rob Newsom expressed the need to continue auditing and the importance of this technology for the well-being of the general public.

“I do want to make sure we emphasize that this is not just being used for crime enforcement,” Newsom said. “It’s being used for other public safety and it does serve and really assist and save lives in that respect.”

Although San Mateo police are not aware of any breaches to its Flock cameras, heightened surveillance and data exposure remains a concern among some San Mateo residents. Multiple community members spoke out against the use of these cameras during the public comment portion of the special meeting.

“Mass surveillance cameras violate our civil rights and make us all less safe,” Emily Morris, San Mateo resident and member of Safety Over Surveillance in San Mateo, said. “They track us everywhere we go, regardless of whether or not we’re suspected of a crime.”

On the other hand, San Mateo resident Michael Ragan, supports the technology, and said he is willing to give up some of his personal privacy for “the good of our public safety.”

“I think the rest of the community should think about it before they turn their backs on this type of technology,” he said.

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